

THE PRIMACY OF SOFTNESS

A Non-Confrontational Philosophy of Being

Kaixuan Wang

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Foreword

Kaixuan Wang has asked me to write a foreword for her new book, *The Primacy of Softness*. Having read the complete manuscript, I find myself genuinely moved by her journey as both artist and thinker.

Years ago, I first guided her into the world of watercolor. Since then, I have watched her evolve, step by step, from a rigorous technical practitioner into an artist with a deep, hard-won understanding of what creative practice actually is.

What sets Kaixuan apart, above all, is her extraordinary perseverance — a relentless, almost stubborn commitment to the work. Among her peers this has simply come to be called the "Kaixuan spirit." She has immersed herself in watercolor, printmaking, oil painting, and traditional Chinese painting, weaving what she has learned from each into a visual language entirely her own. Her watercolors carry the lyricism of Chinese ink wash, the structural rigor of printmaking, and the rich texture of oil painting. Years of steady, consistent practice have earned her real recognition — including two qualification awards from the China Artists Association, falling just one point short of full membership.

But today, her achievement reaches far beyond technical mastery. Through her long engagement with water, light, color, and the passage of time, she has quietly forged an artistic philosophy that is entirely her own.

Watercolor practice is never simply a matter of skill. It demands constant negotiation with uncertainty, a delicate balance between control and yielding — in many ways, a lifelong discipline of self-cultivation.

The core concept of this book — what Kaixuan calls the primacy of softness — emerges directly out of this lived experience. Rather than treating creation as an act of mastery or domination, she approaches it as a practice of openness, transformation, and quiet self-unfolding. Within watercolor's fluid, unpredictable

nature, she has found a creative force that flourishes not through struggle, but through harmonious relation.

In this book, she distills what she has learned into five essential movements: Pause, Receive, Generate, Permeate, and Light. Rooted in hands-on creative practice, these ideas also open into a broader meditation on how we might engage with life itself.

As her mentor, what I value most is not her technical excellence but her inner maturation into an independent artistic thinker in her own right. For this reason, *The Primacy of Softness* is far more than a book about art. It is a genuine reflection on how a person might find their place in the world, and continue that inner maturation amid its constant change.

Chen Zhongke

May 1, 2026

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